WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

BELARUS

Europe

Information current as of November 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Minsk	Capital and main business centre; seat of the government, the National Bank and most state holding companies	IT services, manufacturing, finance (subject to sanctions perimeter)
Great Stone Industrial Park (Minsk region)	China–Belarus industrial park of 117.6 sq km with 87 residents from 15 countries and tax benefits running to 2062	Engineering, electronics, pharmaceuticals, logistics, R&D
Soligorsk (Minsk region)	Home of Belaruskali, one of the world's largest potash producers, removed from the US sanctions list in March 2026 but still under EU restrictions	Potash and fertilisers (EU and UK restrictions apply)
Brest	Main rail and road gateway on the Poland border and on the China–Europe rail corridor	Transit logistics, warehousing, food processing
Grodno	Western city near the Polish and Lithuanian borders with chemicals and agri-food industries	Chemicals, food processing, light manufacturing
Gomel and Mogilev	Eastern industrial regions with engineering, wood-processing and agricultural bases linked to the Russian market	Machine-building, timber and pulp, agriculture
Vitebsk	North-eastern region bordering Russia and Latvia, with textiles and food processing	Light industry, food processing

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Sanctions licensing route: US (OFAC), UK (OFSI and the Department for Business and Trade) and EU national competent authorities issue licences; US general licences now cover Belavia (GL 11) and Belinvestbank (GL 14)
- US partial relief since 2025: Belaruskali, the Belarusian Potash Company and Agrorozkvit were removed from the US sanctions list in March 2026, and Lakokraska and Bellesbumprom were relieved in September 2026; the EU and UK have not followed
- Great Stone Industrial Park: corporate income tax exemption for 10 years from first profit, then half the national rate, and property and land-tax exemptions until 2062, for investments from $500,000
- National Agency of Investment and Privatization, which promotes investment, and investment agreements with the state for priority projects, for investors from non-sanctioning jurisdictions

- Eurasian Economic Union membership and the Union State with Russia, giving tariff-free access to EAEU markets
- Normalisation-readiness route: maintaining compliant entities, contracts and relationships so that investors can act promptly if sanctions are lawfully eased further

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Belarus has an export-oriented industrial economy, with GDP growth of 1.3% in 2025 and 2.1% in January–July 2026 against a government target of 2.8%. Inflation was a moderate 4.6% in September 2026, and the National Bank cut its refinancing rate to 9.25% from 1 June 2026. Gold and foreign exchange reserves were $14.6 billion on 1 October 2026, and foreign trade reached $89.8 billion in 2025, with exports of $41.4 billion. Since late 2025, the United States has eased part of its sanctions in step with the release of political prisoners, including 250 people freed in March 2026 and 25 more in September: it has authorised dealings with Belavia, removed the main potash companies from its sanctions list, rescinded its directive on the Ministry of Finance and the Development Bank, and relieved further industrial companies. US officials have linked further relief to further releases.

Belarus's defining feature for international investors is the legal environment created by its support for Russia's war against Ukraine and by domestic repression. The EU renewed its sanctions in February 2026 for one year without change, keeping 312 individuals and 57 entities listed together with broad restrictions on trade, finance, transport and energy, including a potash ban whose application to transit through Lithuania was upheld by the EU General Court in 2026. The UK maintains its own wide-ranging Belarus sanctions regime, and the EU and US did not recognise the January 2025 presidential election. For compliant investors, the opportunity lies in two areas: lawfully permitted activity, where US relief has widened the scope for US persons in particular, and careful readiness for any further easing, given Belarus's skilled workforce, industrial base and position on the China–Europe transit route.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
EU and UK sanctions	Comprehensive EU and UK measures restrict trade, finance, transport, energy and potash, and freeze the assets of listed people and entities	Engage sanctions counsel in every relevant jurisdiction; confine activity to permitted sectors and licensed transactions
Divergent US and EU positions	US relief, for example on Belaruskali, does not change EU or UK law, so the same transaction may be lawful for some parties and prohibited for others	Map each party's nationality and each payment route; obtain licences or legal opinions in every jurisdiction involved
Remaining US sanctions	US officials expect part of the US measures to remain while Belarus supports Russia's war, and many entities remain on the US list	Screen every counterparty against current OFAC lists; monitor further general licences linked to prisoner releases
Links to Russia and secondary-sanctions risk	Belarus is closely integrated with Russia through the Union State and EAEU, so Russia-related sanctions often apply	Apply Russia-sanctions screening to Belarusian deals, including ownership chains and end-use of goods
Border and transit disruption	Lithuania closed its Belarus border crossings in late 2025 after smuggling-balloon incidents, leaving trucks stranded	Plan alternative routes and buffer stocks; crossings reopened on 19 November 2025
Human rights and reputational risk	Rights groups report 886 political prisoners as of September 2026	Conduct enhanced human-rights due diligence and stakeholder review before any engagement
Uncertain timing of normalisation	US relief is incremental and the EU renewed its measures unchanged in February 2026	Build scenarios for both continued restrictions and phased easing so decisions can be taken quickly and lawfully

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Belarus offers a skilled workforce, an industrial and IT base, moderate inflation of 4.6% and reserves of $14.6 billion, and the United States has eased part of its sanctions since late 2025 in return for prisoner releases. However, EU and UK sanctions remain comprehensive and were renewed by the EU in February 2026, covering trade, finance, transport, energy and potash, and the EU and US did not recognise the 2025 presidential election. Belarus's support for Russia's war against Ukraine means Russia-related sanctions and export controls often also apply. Investors must take specialist sanctions advice in every relevant jurisdiction, confine any activity to what is lawfully permitted for each party, and never use Belarus to route trade or payments that would be prohibited elsewhere. The opportunity is therefore limited to lawful activity now and to readiness for any further, lawful normalisation.

MARKET ACCESS

Belarus is a member of the Eurasian Economic Union and the Union State with Russia, giving tariff-free access to Russia, Kazakhstan, Armenia and Kyrgyzstan; it is not a WTO member. Foreign trade reached $89.8 billion in 2025, with Russia and other EAEU members the main partners. Brest sits on the main China–Europe rail corridor, but EU sanctions restrict many Belarusian goods and road carriers in the EU, potash cannot transit Lithuania to Klaipėda, and border crossings with Lithuania were closed temporarily in late 2025. As a result, exports flow mainly east and through Russian ports.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Presidential Administration (President Alexander Lukashenko)	Concentrates political and economic decision-making; leads talks with the US envoy on prisoner releases and sanctions relief; the EU does not recognise the 2025 election	Engagement only within sanctions rules and after legal advice
Council of Ministers (Prime Minister Alexander Turchin)	Runs economic policy, state enterprises and investment programmes	Relevant for state-sector counterparts in permitted sectors
National Bank of the Republic of Belarus	Sets the refinancing rate (9.25% since June 2026) and manages $14.6 billion of reserves	Key reference for currency, banking and payments
National Agency of Investment and Privatization	State investment promotion agency handling investor enquiries and investment agreements	First point of contact for investors from non-sanctioning jurisdictions
Great Stone Industrial Park Administration	Manages the China–Belarus park and its residents' special tax regime	Counterpart for manufacturing and R&D projects, subject to sanctions screening
Belaruskali	State potash producer, delisted by the US in March 2026 but subject to EU and UK restrictions	Engagement depends on each party's sanctions jurisdiction
Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Leads relations with the US and the EU, including the sanctions-relief process	Useful for monitoring normalisation signals

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

Formal Western business channels with Belarus are limited by sanctions, and Western development lenders are not currently a route for new projects. The Belarusian Chamber of Commerce and Industry and the Great Stone Park Administration are the main local business contacts, and Chinese and Russian partners are prominent in current investment. For Western investors, the most useful channels are specialist sanctions counsel, embassy commercial and political sections, and industry associations that track the US relief process, together with the US envoy's announcements on prisoner releases and further licences.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Belarus is currently suited only to a narrow range of investors: existing operators maintaining licensed or permitted activities; US persons in sectors now covered by US relief, such as potash trading or aviation-related services, where no EU or UK nexus arises; investors from non-sanctioning jurisdictions with strong secondary-sanctions

advice; and long-horizon investors keeping a watching brief for further normalisation. Any engagement requires multi-jurisdiction sanctions advice and enhanced human-rights due diligence.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Take sanctions advice in every relevant jurisdiction
Confirm what US, EU, UK and other rules allow for each party, product and payment route before any activity.

STEP 2: Map the US relief precisely
Check current OFAC general licences and delistings, and confirm that no EU or UK nexus makes the activity prohibited.

STEP 3: Screen counterparties and ownership chains
Screen Belarusian partners and their owners against all sanctions lists, including Russia-related designations.

STEP 4: Conduct human-rights and reputational due diligence
Assess labour, supply-chain and reputational risks, and document decisions for boards and lenders.

STEP 5: Prepare for lawful normalisation
Keep scenario plans and compliant relationships ready to act quickly if the EU, UK or US ease further measures.